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WHEN A STOOL MAKES A HUGE DIFFERENCE AT THE POLLING BOOTH

Members of Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association have reiterated a set of demands, one they always make when it is time to head to the hustings **P4**



MEET THREE HEAVYWEIGHTS

Here are three candidates for Autism Acceptance Month; Rupak Rajendra Munje, Ashwath Radha Mohan and M. Ramanathan are doing things that are anything but ordinary **P6**

A noon meeting in Jeth Nagar

Residents meet up with Dha. Velu at Pattammal Street and present their list of demands



Dha. Velu with Jeth Nagar residents

PRINCE FREDERICK

Imagine presenting a list of situations to someone, one by one, and at the end of each line that has presented a scenario, appending a phrase, “as you very well know.” Something approximating to this unfolded at Pattammal Street in Jeth Nagar, Mandaveli on a recent scorching afternoon. A DMK candidate in Mylapore Assembly constituency and the sitting MLA, Dha. Velu was meeting up with residents of Jeth Nagar. And not long ago, he had himself been a resident of Jeth Nagar.

Ravi Nandyala, founder-member, Jeth Nagar Residents’ Association (JERA), observes: “He was a resident of Third Cross Street in Jeth Nagar. “ And therefore, he is

hugely familiar with both the harrowing and niggling issues in the neighbourhood.

The meeting did away with formalities. It did not unfold in air-conditioned comfort, but out in the sweltering sun.

“He met us at Pattammal Street at 12 noon sharp. We chose this street for the parley because it is plagued by more issues than the other streets in Jeth Nagar. There are nine streets in the neighbourhood,” Ravi begins. “In Jeth Nagar, a structured system is in place, one that has one representative for each street. Residents were open in their interaction, conveying upfront that no systemic issues had to be dealt with and that they generally maintained a good working relationship with civic authorities. Most concerns are routed through a single

point of contact: either I or another representative, Uma Shivkumar. Typically, once issues are communicated, action is taken, though sometimes with delays.” During the discussion, two demands stood out for the urgency with which they were made.

Vending zones

Ravi notes that a request for designation of vending zones was made so that vending does not cut across the streets. “The intention is not to invite more vendors into residential spaces, but rather to regulate and confine vending activity to designated zones so that streets are not indiscriminately occupied,” Ravi elaborates.

Public sanitation facilities
Misuse of public spaces for

open urination is a thorn in the side for Jeth Nagar residents; they raised it with Dha. Velu.

“People frequently use the area near Mandaveli MRTS station and the temporary bus stop right next to it as an open toilet, particularly near the Buckingham Canal,” Ravi points out.

Even more concerning is the situation near Jeth Nagar First Cross Street, where

commuters exiting the MRTS station enter the area near Sri Venugopal Vidyalaya and urinate along the school compound walls.”

Currently, there are no public toilet facilities in these areas. Ravi notes they requested the construction of a public toilet near the Canal where sufficient space is available.

While talking to *The Hindu Downtown* Ravi won-

dered why toilets within MRTS stations are non-functional or closed.

Ravi underlines that Dha. Velu’s accessibility (“appointments are granted promptly, often on the same day”) is a great comfort factor. The JERA founder-member is all praise for 126 councillor Amirdha Varshini for her prompt intervention whenever her help is sought.

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From the meet.

PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The event was conceptualised and planned by a dedicated committee of past students who remember “Padmasri Ma’am” not just as a teacher, but as a career-defining mentor.

“Padmasri Ma’am was not just teaching us how to balance accounts; she was teaching us accountability, integrity and preparing us for the ‘real world’ of business, says a member of the organising committee and an alumni of the school. “This farewell is a small token of gratitude from us who found our footing in the professional world thanks to her guidance.”

The event commenced with a batchwise attendance, group rendition of school prayer, followed by an engaging Q&A session, a departure from traditional speeches. “Padmasri Ma’am” shared a poignant message that resonated deeply with the audience: “Remember, integrity is your only non-depreciating asset. Protect it fiercely. Make your life a ‘Going Concern’ that people can trust without question.” She thanked the management of P S Senior Secondary School, all the principals she worked under, colleagues and most importantly her students who attended this event from across the world. The celebration concluded with a series of group photographs where Padmasri Ma’am posed with individual alumni batches.

Honour for legendary accountancy teacher

A grand farewell was organised for Padmasri Nirmal Kumar, who retired from P.S. Senior Secondary School in Mylapore

The alumni of P. S. Senior Secondary School, Commerce stream hosted a grand farewell for their beloved accountancy teacher, Padmasri Nirmal Kumar, on April 11, 2026, at The Residency Towers in T. Nagar.

A press release notes Padmasri Nirmal Kumar joined P.S. Senior Secondary School in 1991. Over her 35-year tenure, she became a cornerstone of the commerce department. Beyond the ledger, Padmasri Nirmal Kumar served as a mentor to thousands of students, many of

whom have gone on to become successful Chartered Accountants, lawyers and industry leaders.

Following her official retirement in March 2026, her former students came together and organised a tribute that reflects the profound impact she had on their profession-

al and personal lives.

Alumni batches spanning from 1993, current faculty, Nirmal Kumar (Padmasri mam’s husband and HOD Commerce Department at A.M.Jain College) and family members of the teacher were in attendance, the release notes.

SRMIST secures ANRF-PM Early Career Research Grant

SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) has secured ten grants under the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)-Prime Minister Early Career Research Grant Scheme with a cumulative funding of around ₹ 6.03 crore.

Across disciplines such as chemistry, nanotechnology, physics, medical research, and genetic engineering, these projects focus on emerging areas, including advanced materials, AI-driven research, healthcare innovation, and sustainable technologies, a press release stated. At a Research Day event on Friday, Shivkumar Kalyanaraman, CEO, ANRF, highlighted opportunities through ANRF, including large-scale funding and industry-linked initiatives.

P. Sathyanarayanan, Pro-Chancellor (Academics), SRMIST, C. Muthamizhchelvan, Vice Chancellor, SRMIST, and B. Venkatachalapathy, Research Professor, SRMIST, were among those present.

1985 batch of St. Bede’s School offers scholarship

This initiative is an extension of its 40th year reunion

In continuation of the celebration of 40th year reunion of the 1985 batch of St. Bede’s Anglo-Indian Higher Secondary School in Santhome held early this year, a “task force team” approached the school management and expressed its desire to give scholarship to deserving students. Seventeen students studying in the school, across classes VI to IX, were recommended and given ₹10,000 each as scholarship to meet a part of their annual school fees, says a press release.

The school management organised a meeting with school students on April 13 at the school’s old auditorium. The task force team consisting of M.A. Sivakumar, Sundaravel, Muthukumar, Roche Vincent, Cyril Gerald, Roohan Williams, M.K. Paul and Aloysius distributed the scholarship amount. The meeting was addressed by headmaster Father John Peter, who



appreciated the 1985 batch’s initiative. Father K.J. Antony and Cyril Gerard also spoke. The task force team expressed their

deep gratitude to the school for providing them with a strong academic foundation, discipline and opportunities in extracur-

ricular activities, which played a crucial role in shaping their careers and personal lives, the release adds.

Visalakshi Jambunathan, a resident of Kallukaran Street in Mylapore, suffered a stroke seven years ago. Despite that, she headed to the polling booth in previous elections. This time around, she decided to make it easy for herself by opting for home voting; and she found the process to be easier than she expected it to be

LIFFY THOMAS

They want to fulfill their duty. And they want to fulfill it from the safety of their home due to their fragile health and advanced age.

Voting for senior citizens above 85 years and for voters with disabilities that have expressed preference to vote from home commenced in all 16 Assembly constituencies in Chennai on April 16.

A team of six comprising a micro observer, two polling officials, a police officer, a videographer and a driver landed at 74-year-old Visalakshi Jambunathan's house at Kallukaran Street in Mylapore around 11 a.m. after a word from the Booth Level Officer.

While the former chemistry teacher from Vidya Mandir Senior Secondary School in Mylapore is happy to be the first in her family and friends circles to have voted

Easy does it; just vote from home



A senior citizen from Royapuram Assembly constituency shows her inked finger and (below) V. Santhanam with polling officials.

PHOTOS : B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

from home, she was missing something. "We are so used to getting our finger inked after voting, but here they took my signature as proof that I have voted and have scratched my name from the list,"

says Visalakshi.

Seven years ago, following a stroke, the teacher suffered disability in her left leg and since then she uses splint to walk.

"My handicap has not limited

me where my routine is concerned. I still go about doing all my work. As this option was available, I thought, 'Why not use it?'. The officials had come home a month ago to verify the details that I had presented through Form 12D," says the former school teacher who has never missed voting.

Eight-eight-year-old V. Santhanam is always on the go, taking up civic issues with elected representatives and officials.

"I can easily walk down to the booth but I wanted to experience the system and I have to commend how the Election Commission has organised this," says the social activist from Chromepet.

He is of the opinion that many senior citizens are not aware of the "vote from home" option and more awareness about it needs to be created.

Old age homes

At Vishranthi Old Age Home in Palavakkam, five residents availed this option. All of them are bed-ridden but had expressed interest in voting, so the management made all the necessary arrangements. At least six others will be going to the polling booths to cast their vote.

At Anandhanam Old Age Home in Ambattur, one of the first things the management wants the residents to do is update the address on their Aadhar card and other documents. This is helpful to avail various benefits offered by the government to senior citizens, and comes handy during election time. This time, 20 people exercised their vote.

According to a report in *The Hindu*, with 106 requests, Kolathur has the highest number of persons with disabilities who have availed themselves of the home voting facility in Chennai. Royapuram has the lowest, with just 14 home voters.

Home voters in each constituency

Velachery
1,064

Thiyagarayanagar
1,005

Kolathur
906

Anna Nagar
855

Virugambakkam
745

Mylapore
725

Thousand Lights
657

Saidapet
531

Perambur
459

Villivakkam
430

Egmore
344

Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni
327

Figures of persons who will be voting under the category of senior citizens, absentee voters and persons with disabilities

C.I.T. Colony's list of demands for candidates

C.I.T. Colony Residents' Welfare Association, which comes under Ward 119 (Zone IX) of Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni constituency, has drafted a set of demands for the contesting candidates.

The colony is home to more than 300 families and many of the amenities need to be upgraded

Among the concerns raised by the RWA are the necessity of replacing the 30-year-old transformers with Ring Main Units (RMUs).

Residents want safety audit of all transformers, including those on private property to be conducted.

The stormwater drain covers in many of the streets have sunk due to road work and they have asked that these be replaced before the North East Monsoon.

As in many other neighbourhoods, unauthorised parking is a growing concern and residents want only single-side parking to be allowed. They have asked that those vehicles falling foul of this parking regulation should be towed away, and the RWA could coordinate for 'Residents Only' stickers.

Relaying all pavements in CIT Colony with paver blocks and a quarterly review meeting with MLA, ward councillor and Zone 9 AE are among other demands.

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When a **stool** makes a huge difference at the polling booth



ILLUSTRATION:
SEBASTIAN FRANCIS

Members of Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association have reiterated a set of demands, one they always make when it is time to head to the hustings

LIFFY THOMAS

Every election, when Dayanand walks into the polling booth at Ranipet in Vellore, he has a prayer on his lips. He needs a prop to be able to vote comfortably and correctly. He needs a stool. Standing just two feet tall, the 28-year-old struggles to press the right button on the electronic voting machine when there is no stool for him to stand on.

Dayanand has been contemplating seeking the 'vote from home' option.

A stool at the polling booth is a unique need faced by those with dwarfism, one of the 21 disabilities in the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016.

Every election, they make this need felt ahead of the visit to the hustings.

At three-and-a-half feet, M.G. Rakul is at a slight advantage. "But I strain to get hold of the right button I want to press," says the Ekkaduthangal resident. Many a time, he has pressed the button on the bottom of the EVM list where his fingers would reach first, unwittingly voting for a political party whose position he does not endorse.

Most people with dwarfism hate to be carried and such experiences at the polling booth leave them with an unpleasant feeling.

In the recently concluded Assembly elections in Kerala, there are reports about a dwarf voter in Thiruvananthapuram who brought his personal stool so that he can vote at ease.

Assistance at booth

Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association has made two other requests to the Election Commission. They want a separate line for persons with disabilities at polling stations and volunteers to assist them till the end when the distance from the drop-off point and polling booth is far.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, R. Gopinath's wife, who was recovering from a surgery, found it a herculean task to walk from the drop-off point to the booth.

"The booth in Manali where we voted had wheelchairs and ramps but none to help those who need assistance from the drop-off point," says Gopinath, who heads the Tamil Nadu Dwarfism Association.

In the parliamentary elections, Greater Chennai Corporation had chosen 21 persons to represent different groups of the differently-abled to ensure polling booths were disabled-friendly, but this time none from the dwarfism community was invited.

Despite their request not being met, the community is clear they want to vote and will nudge all others with a valid voting identity card to participate in the process. "There are more than 500 people with dwarfism in Tamil Nadu, and at least 100 in Chennai," says Gopinath.

The Association has sent reminders to all members to exercise their vote. Says Rakul: "This time, we are even asking our members to use the Saksham App and request for a volunteer in advance at the polling booth, but downloading the app and making a request is not easy for many of us."

For a copy of Voter ID

If your name is on the electoral roll and your mobile number is registered with the Election Commission of India and linked to your EPIC, you can download a copy of your voter ID online from <https://voters.eci.gov.in>

For quick assistance

Voter helpline numbers

1950/ 1800 425 0424

Official website

www.elections.tn.gov.in

What to take to the booth

* Obviously, the Voter Identification Card

* If you are on the electoral roll, your number registered with ECI, but do not have the Voter ID Card at present, it would help to carry any of these documents with you: Aadhaar Card, PAN card, Indian Passport, Driving Licence or Pension Documents

Need support on *election day?*

Inclusive vehicle to take voters to polling booth



Vidya Sagar, an NGO working for persons with disabilities, has procured an additional vehicle as part of its 'Get Going' initiative that helps those with disabilities travel comfortably in an inclusive vehicle. As in previous years, two of these vehicles will be pressed into service for senior citizens and PwDs wanting to reach the polling booth without any hassle.

The vehicle is equipped with a hydraulic lift and can accommodate up to three wheelchairs with four addi-

tional seats. There are specially trained support staff to meet the needs of the special-needs people.

The NGO charges a fee based on distance between the home and polling booth for ferrying

the voter. During other times of the year, these vehicles are used to take students on a field trips. **The vehicle has to be booked at least a day in advance. For bookings, call 9444398182.**



Help at the polling station

If you know someone who would need a wheelchair or a sign language interpreter at the polling booth then ask them to download the Election Commission of India's Saksham App. This tool for persons with disabilities allows them to participate in the electoral process with some degree of ease. It offers them a number of features including how to find their polling station.

The mobile application is currently making sure there is wheelchair support at the polling booth, Indian Sign Language Interpreter and help to deal

with other concerns. The App requires one to place a request in advance so that a volunteer can be arranged on polling day.

A sign language interpreter working with the team says they have close to 15 interpreters and the requests placed on the App are by individuals as well as associations working for PwDs.

In the 2024 Lok Sabha Elections, most polling stations only had a booth where one could reach out for any assistance. A sign language interpreter says, "Through a video call made from the stall, we were assisting the deaf and the mute. This time, the plan is to have both."



Special buses

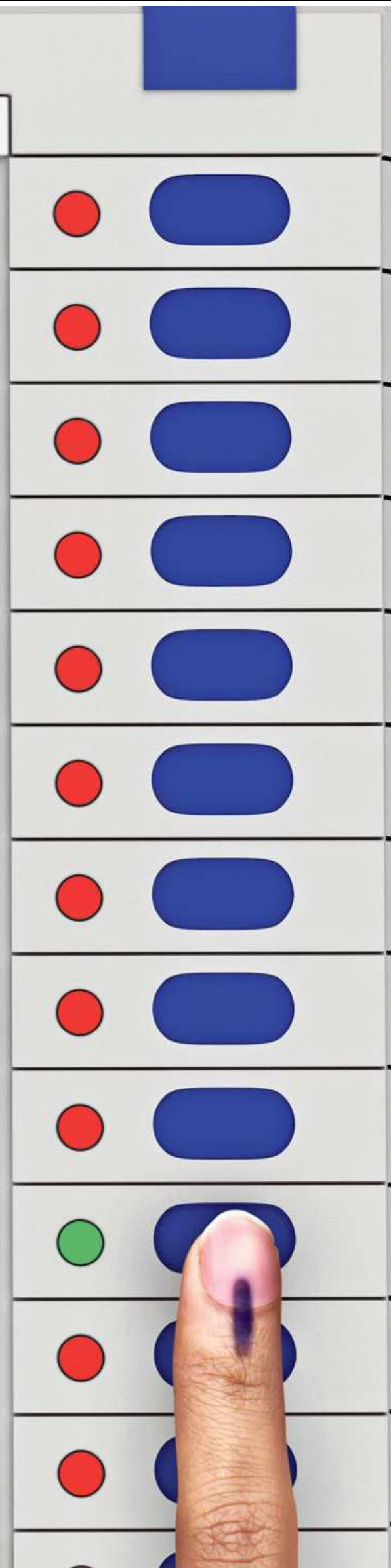
Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation will ply special long-distance buses from April 21 to 23 to enable people to get their polling booth without much difficulty.

From Kalaignar Centenary Bus Terminus (KCBT) in Kilambak-

kam, buses will operate to Pudukcherry, Cuddalore, Chidambaram, Trichy, Madurai, Tuticorin and Coimbatore. At Koyambedu, find buses going to East Coast Road, Vellore, Thiruttani and Bengaluru. From Madhavaram New Bus Stand, there are buses to Andhra Pradesh via Ponneri,

Gummidipoondi, and to Trichy, Salem, Kumbakonam, and Thiruvannamalai. The public can book tickets online through www.tnsrc.in and on the official Tamil Nadu State Transport Corporation app.

To learn more about bus routes, call 94450 14436.



This is the month for assessing candidates; meet three heavyweights

Here are three candidates for Autism Acceptance Month. In fact, everyone on the spectrum is qualified to represent the month. But sadly, this twisted world sits up and takes notice only when extraordinary achievements are on the horizon; and Rupak Rajendra Munje, Ashwath Radha Mohan and M. Ramanathan are doing things that are anything but ordinary

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

Colours without words



For Rupak Rajendra Munje, colour arrived before language. At 29, this abstract artist has built a quiet but steady presence through canvases filled with fluid strokes, layered pigments and the distinctive drip patterns that have come to define his work. Non-verbal and on the autism spectrum, Rupak communicates largely through art – a practice that began as therapy and gradually evolved into purpose.

Born in Hyderabad and now living at Ranjith Road in Kotturpuram, Rupak was diagnosed with autism and intellectual disability at the age of two-and-a-half. His mother, Ranjana Rajendra Munje, recalls the uncertainty that followed. “There was very little awareness about autism then. We were completely clueless and had to slowly learn about therapies, special education and structured support to help him,” she says.

Art entered his life during an autism awareness programme at Forum Art Gallery in Adyar, where he was introduced to free painting. What began as sensory engagement soon developed into a sustained artistic practice, with abstract compositions, layered

textures and drip-based forms becoming central to his work. His father, Rajendra Munje, a fine arts graduate and former advertising professional, stepped away from commercial work to mentor him closely. “We give him a blank canvas and allow him to express freely. He creates first, and we try to understand the art later. It is a do-think process,” he says, adding that he often spends hours interpreting and titling Rupak’s abstract works so viewers can connect with them.

Rupak’s art has since travelled widely, with exhibitions in Delhi, Bangalore and Kochi, and showcases in international galleries, including in Geneva. He has received fellowships from India Inclusion Foundation and Hyundai Art for Hope, and the Tata Steel Foundation’s Sabal Award. One of his most recognised works – a fluid drip painting – was adapted into a mug design by The Indian Twist during the pandemic, bringing his artwork into everyday spaces. Rupak’s journey is also the subject of a 23-minute documentary, *A Palette of Emotions*, by filmmaker Rahul Manoj, which explores the Munje family’s acceptance of autism and their shared engagement with art.

‘Cooking up’ confidence

One afternoon at his home in Vettuvankeni, M. Ramanathan took charge of the kitchen. When his mother stepped away for a work call, leaving half-prepared pasta on the counter, Ramanathan turned to his grandmother and began guiding her through each step, pointing to ingredients, signalling what needed to be added next, and ensuring the dish was completed. By the time his mother returned, the pasta was ready.

“That was the moment I realised how confident he had become,” says his mother, S. Subbulakshmi. “He knew the process and was able to communicate and get the work done.”

Diagnosed with autism at a young age, Ramanathan has gradually built independence through his interest in cooking. His journey began at home, where he observed his grandmother in the kitchen and started helping with small tasks such as arranging ingredients and cutting vegetables.

Structured training at The CanBridge Academy in Thiruvannamiyur helped develop this interest further through step-by-step visual instructions and routine-based learning. The training later led to an internship at Uncle Sam’s Kitchen, where Ramanathan worked in an inclusive environment preparing vegetables and assisting in meal preparation. Twenty-six years old now, Ramanathan now continues to work there and receives a stipend.



“Cooking came naturally to him because he is a keen observer,” Subbulakshmi says. “The internship helped him gain confidence and understand a work routine.”

Biryani, pulao and pasta are among his favourite dishes, and he often assists with cooking at home. His communication, she adds, has improved through structured routines and workplace exposure.

“Autism is just one part of his life,” she says. “What matters is that he has found something he enjoys and is able to work with confidence and dignity.”

Finding his voice

Thiruvannamiyur resident Ashwath Radha Mohan’s day shuttles between work and music, these two engagements bringing a balance to his life, one he managed with persistence and the steady support of those around him.

Twenty-eight now, Ashwath was diagnosed with autism at the age of three; he was non-verbal until nearly seven. After brief forays into what proved to be choppy waters of mainstream school-

ing, he found himself sailing at an even keel at Alpha Omega, a special school that allowed him to develop independence at his own pace. He would go on to complete both his BSc and MSc in Visual Communication.

Professionally, Ashwath has eased into structured work, having previously worked at Cloud Designs on corporate gift design and currently with Saras Media, where he handles presentations and communication-related tasks while working partly from home.

Music has remained the constant thread in his life. As an infant, he would sit upright and listen intently when

never film songs played, revealing an early sensitivity to sound. Years later, a Hindustani music teacher was struck by his instinctive grasp of pitch and rhythm. The turning point came during the pandemic, when his mother, Sheeba Sojanar, encouraged him to sing and share recordings. This led him to Samagra, a collective of neurodivergent and visually impaired musicians, where Ashwath now performs at concerts, weddings and public events, earning recognition and professional payment. He continues voice culture and hopes to participate in reality singing competitions.

“I think 60% of Ashwath’s journey is his own hard work and the rest is the love and acceptance he received from people around him,” says Sheeba. “There is nothing wrong in being autistic, it is just being different, and I am very proud of my son.”



READERS WRITE

An affable vendor at CPR Road

Many residents are of the view that Vennila sells flowers and fruits at reasonable prices

BASKAR SESHADRI

Meeet Vennila, who has her pavement shop opposite Kirthilals and near Kolkata Chat on CP Ramaswamy Road.

In 1990, when she was in her 20s, she started a small flower and fruit shop on the pavement between Dr Ranga Road and CP Ramaswamy Road.

A workaholic, she attends to all home-related chores in the morning, and after visiting the market heads to the shop around 5 p.m. She has all kinds of flowers and fruits and sells them at prices that are always nominal.

A native of Tindivanam, Vennila settled in Chennai and has her house in Kapali Thottam. If you are looking for fruits or flowers even in the midnight, you can count on this kind vendor who is content with the little money she makes every day.

Vennila can be reached on 9092 311 392.

Baskar Seshadri is a resident of Mylapore



Run for ethical voting

Voters Association of India, in association with Election Commission of India, is organising a 'Mega Marathon' on April 19 at 5 a.m. to create awareness on 'Ethical Voting and 100% Voting'.

The event is open to all and the online link requires one to sign a declaration that no political party's flag, shirt, badge or any item that resembles any party will be used during the run.

In case you have not signed up for the run starting at Napier Bridge then show your support on 'register to pledge'. Visit <https://votersassociation.com/megamarathon/index.php>

You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in.

Three-day workshop on baking

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conducting a baking workshop from April 28 to 30. According to a press release, the session will focus on making cookies, biscuits, chocolates, and cakes from millets.

The centre is also conducting another training programme on making skincare products from April 28 to 30. The session will

focus on making soaps and shampoos from bio-enzymes, adds the release.

Also, a beautician course will be held from April 21 to 22. Participants will be taught sari draping, hairstyling, and a few more.

All the sessions will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 8668102600 / 87544 95254

Summer camp by ISKCON

ISKCON Chennai is conducting summer camp, both on-line and offline at multiple locations for children and teens on the theme 'Divine Questions and Divine Answers'.

The two-week camp will be conducted in April and May, with English or Tamil as medium of instruction. Children (6 to 12 years) will get to learn with stories, quizzes, shlokas, bhajans, fireless cooking, art and craft while the teens would have theme-based stories, debates, discussions and JAM sessions.

Duration of each class is 1.5 - 2 hours. One must register with a minimal fee.

Course materials such as videos, PDF, PPT will be shared to participants through WhatsApp. Participants will receive a certificate on completion of the course.

For more details and registration, visit <https://bpss.fun/summer-camp/> Call 8072599295.

'India for Global Education'

Panthi Academy, a startup focused on transforming school education, has launched an initiative titled, 'India for Global Education'.

The movement is led by its founder, V. P. Suresh.

Panthi Academy has invited educators and institutions to join. For details, call 9444452336 / 9840136464

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